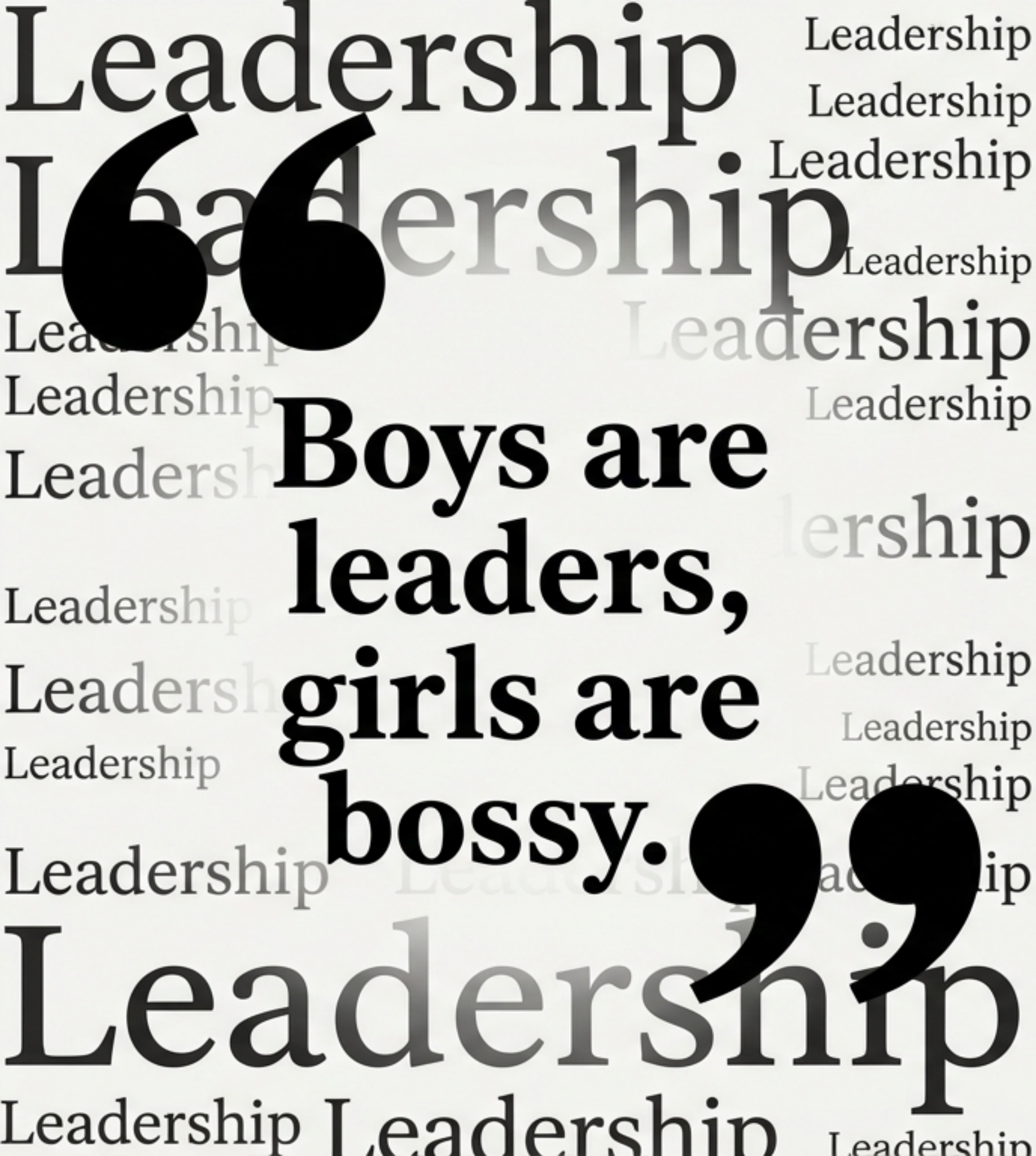


The Forging of a Leader

The Origins of Sheryl Sandberg
& The Lean In Movement

A Reading Deck





The Bossy Trap in Lean In Red

The Sibling Toast: At her wedding, siblings Michelle and David joked they weren't her siblings, but her "first employees."

The Behavior: As a toddler, she taught them to follow her around the house, listen to monologues, and respond "Right!"

The Stigma: Sheryl cringes at the word "bossy." It is a derogatory label for female leadership potential that is rarely used for boys.



The Archetype: Rosalind Einhorn (1917–2000s)

Identity:	Sheryl's Grandmother
Nickname:	'Girlie' (shared with her sister; male cousins had real names)
Education:	Pulled out of high school during the Great Depression to support the family
Crisis Management:	Years later, saved the family paint business from financial ruin

The 'What If' Scenario: A business savior initially removed from school because a boy's education was the only hope.



The Great Depression's Gender Economics

The Sacrifice: Rosalind was removed from school to sew fabric flowers onto undergarments for low pay.

The Norm: "Words such as future and hope were simply not used to describe what a girl could offer."

The Pivot: A teacher shocked by Rosalind's removal begged for her return. She eventually graduated from UC Berkeley, proving that the family's "only hope" wasn't limited to the sons.

Engineering Gender Neutrality

The Sandberg Home Environment

Philosophy:

The Sandberg children were raised to believe girls could do anything boys could do.

The Soundtrack:

This 1972 album was a staple in the household.

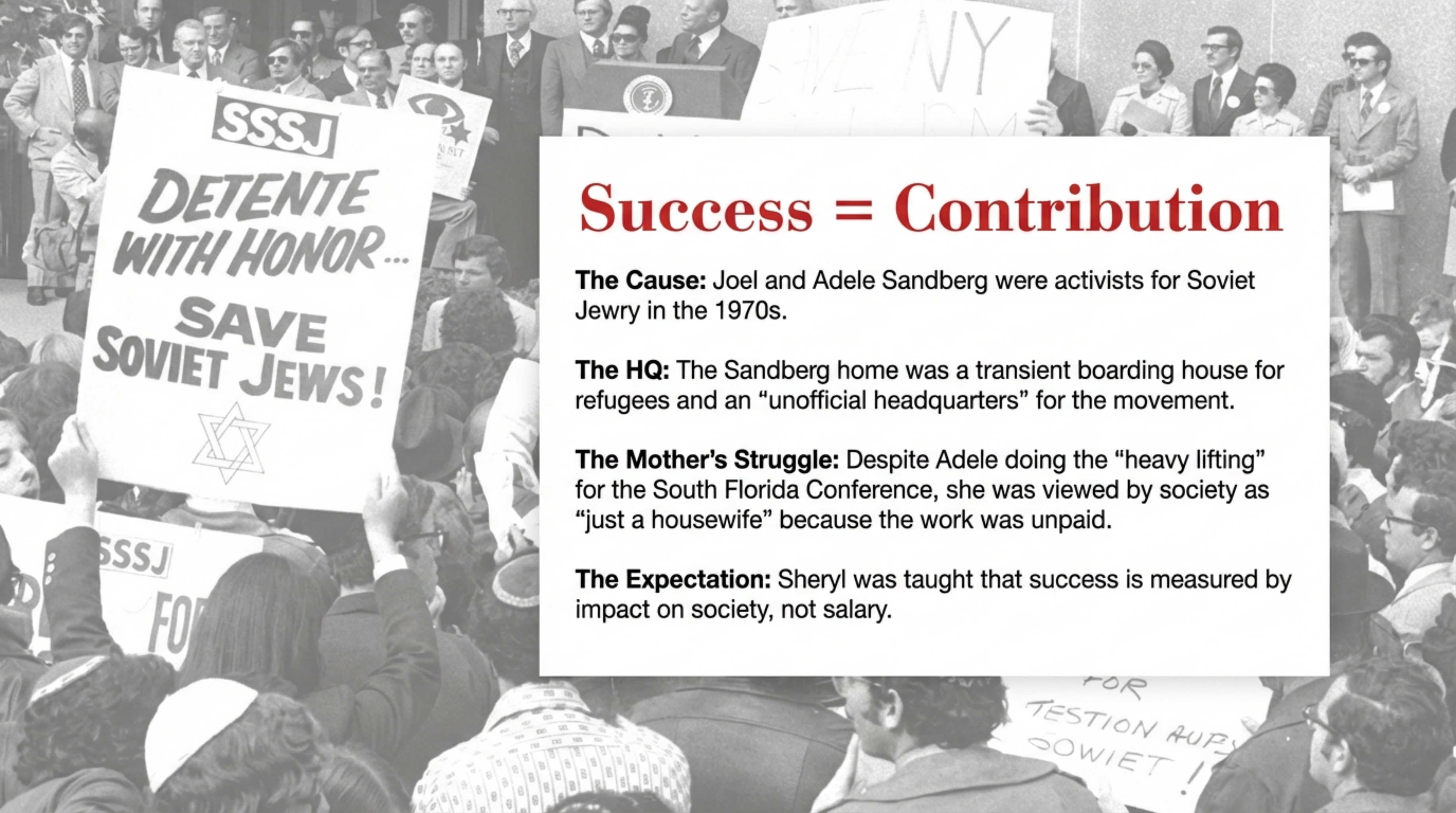


Key Lesson:

Sheryl internalized the song "William Wants a Doll", where a boy is denied a doll despite excelling at "boy" activities.

Sheryl's Takeaway:

Neutralizing stereotypes helps men as much as women. Men deserve the societal support to be caregivers.



Success = Contribution

The Cause: Joel and Adele Sandberg were activists for Soviet Jewry in the 1970s.

The HQ: The Sandberg home was a transient boarding house for refugees and an “unofficial headquarters” for the movement.

The Mother's Struggle: Despite Adele doing the “heavy lifting” for the South Florida Conference, she was viewed by society as “just a housewife” because the work was unpaid.

The Expectation: Sheryl was taught that success is measured by impact on society, not salary.



The Harvard Reality Check

Heroes for Zeroes

- **The Scene:** First day of “The Concept of the Hero in Hellenic Civilization.”
- **The Question:** “Who has read the books in the original Homeric Greek?”
- **The Reaction:** One-third of the class raised their hands. Sheryl did not.
- **The Insight:** For the first time, the high school valedictorian felt like a “**Zero**.” She hovered near the bottom of the class.

The Impostor's Confirmation

“You were not admitted to Harvard based on your academic potential. You were admitted based on your personality.”

— Feedback from Sheryl's Proctor

The Incident: Received a 'C' on a political philosophy paper—considered failing at Harvard.

The Result: Instead of quitting, she learned to work “smarter,” mastering the system and the five-page paper.

Distorting the Truth: Gender & Confidence

Sheryl & Carrie (Female Experience)

- Attended every lecture.
- Read every book.
- Anxious before the final.

Result: Grade A.

Reaction: Shock.



Brother David (Male Experience)

- Skipped lectures.
- Read only one book.
- Crammed via 'crash course' from Sheryl.

Result: Grade A.

Reaction: "I got an A!"
(Arrogance/Confidence).

A lack of self-confidence can be a self-fulfilling prophecy.
Sheryl realized she was distorting the truth of her own abilities.

Fake It 'Til You Make It



The Job: **Sheryl** taught aerobics to pay tuition. She was so popular students lined up around the block.

The Costume: Silver leotard, shiny headband.

The Psychology: Even on bad days, she had to smile. She learned that **forcing the physical action of confidence (smiling)** often triggered the actual emotion.



The Mentor: Lawrence 'Larry' Summers

Public Sector Economics Professor

Initial Thought:

Thought Sheryl was just there to "have a good time" because she never spoke in class.

The Turn:

She submitted the best midterm and final in the class.

The Opportunity:

He advised her senior thesis (Economic Inequality & Spousal Abuse).

The Dynamic:

Summers supported her group "Women in Economics and Government" when no one else would. He recognized her tendency to "always go the extra mile."

Crashing the System



The Task: Inputting thesis data on magnetic tapes at Harvard's single computer center.

The Crash: Sheryl overloaded the system and brought down the *entire* Harvard network.

The Parallel: Twelve years later, Mark Zuckerberg would crash the same Harvard system with "Facemash."

Narrative Note: Neither knew they would eventually run one of the world's largest computer networking companies together.

Feeling Like a Fraud

The Event: Phi Beta Kappa induction ceremony (women's ceremony).

The Speech: The keynote speaker described high-achieving women who feel undeserving of praise and fear exposure as frauds.

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The Reaction: The entire room of women nodded in agreement.

The Diagnosis: "The Impostor Syndrome." Women internalized self-doubt as a defense mechanism because society dislikes women who boast.

Sheryl's Realization: This explained her request to the high school yearbook committee to *not* name her "Most Successful" for fear of losing losing likability.

The Search for Impact



The World Bank (India):

Worked on eradicating leprosy. Moved by the mission, but didn't feel it was her specific calling.

McKinsey (Los Angeles):

A prestigious consulting job. Felt challenged but unfulfilled. Left after one year.

The Pivot:

Returned to DC to find her true purpose, eventually linking back up with Larry Summers at the Treasury.

The Checkbox Trap



The Pressure: Her parents' subtle message: Marry young, get "a good man before they're all taken."

The Decision: She declined overseas work to stay marriageable. Married Brian Kraff at age 24.

The Fall: Divorced one year later.

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The Emotion: Sheryl felt immense shame. She felt she had failed the "good wife" societal test.

The Rebound: It took time, but she rebuilt, eventually creating a new path that wasn't defined by this early "failed this early "failure."

The Chief of Staff



The Role:

At age 29, Sheryl became the youngest Chief of Staff at the Treasury Department under Larry Summers.

The Scale:

She helped oversee a \$14 billion budget.

The Scope:

Participated in economic policy on national and international levels.

Synthesis:

The girl who was called “bossy” was now professionally managing the global economy.

The Forging Complete

From the 'Bossy' girl in Miami...

To the 'Zero' at Harvard...

To the 'Impostor' in the Phi Beta
Kappa hall...

**Leaders are not born; they are forged
through the rejection of limiting narratives
and the embracing of their own power.**

We've come a long way, but...

